

interests), and the more functional and feature rich distros have to be purchased. Because of the way the Linux kernel itself is licensed, the source code will always be provided with such distros, and you can do what you want with them. While taking a corporate decision to switch to Linux, considerations such as the time taken to adjust to Linux, train employees, and the reduction in productivity in the interim period have to be considered.

Linux is not for geeks only anymore, and the lay man can use it, but all the good things about Linux are beyond the scope of the lay user. The best example of this is the open source code, most users of Linux will not know what to do with it, and will never want to know either. Installing, using and finding applications are no longer difficult in Linux, but they are not as easy as doing the same for Windows either.

Linux is not entirely bug free, and there are as many obscure pop-ups and system error messages as Windows. Linux also crashes pretty frequently, and such moments can be extremely frustrating and stop a beginner from sticking at it.

A Linux installation, when inexpertly handled, can mess up your hard drive. Even if your data is backed up, you might see a portion of your hard drive mysteriously disappear after you have installed Linux and then go back to Windows. On a day to day basis, your computer technician will begin to hate you if you install Linux then call him for help. More true for your ISP provider, who might be as confused as you are in case you run into connectivity problems. Installing codecs on your Linux distribution is notoriously difficult, and although a lot of support is available on forums across the Internet, they are so technical in appearance, that it is enough to scare a new user away. You absolutely need an Internet connection for installing most software, because of the way the dependencies have to be resolved in almost every distro available. Most importantly, don't expect to work on Linux without getting down and dirty with it, that is going into the command line, tweaking around with root access (which can really mess up your system) or basically being ready to learn a bit and get deeper into the heart of computing.

There needs to be at least a small techie in your heart for you to flirt with Linux, despite what anyone claims. Linux still has a long way to go before it can be at par with the latest releases of Windows or Mac OS, and Trovalds is taking his own sweet time making everyone wait for Linux 3.0. That said, it is not that difficult a thing to handle, and at times can be a very rewarding experience. So, let's start getting down and dirty.